

responsibilities for an internship,” she sighed. One unpaid internship involved social media work for a self-published author for college credit.

At first, she felt it was all worth it. “I need to do this if I’m going to advance,” she thought. “I had to slog through things in order to get someplace.”

But she soon found she was at the mercy of the quirks of this nonpaying employer. Did he want to put her name on her work? Up to him. Did he want to give her references or help her make connections? Up to him. There was no guarantee or protection.

This blows.

In some undergraduate departments like hers (English), it was strongly encouraged (but not required) that students do an unpaid internship. In other departments (for example, the chemistry department), unpaid internships were mandatory to graduate. And then—this is fucked up—Kayla said there was the opportunity to do a special course with an internship in which a student could negotiate for payment from her boss for work like creating a website or writing a book, but then the payment goes to the school. “[The school] gets the money that they would have paid to you if you were a freelancer,” she explained.

This is technically legal, if not ethical. And it’s definitely bullshit.

Kayla also told me she suffered physical symptoms of stress from her internship. She cried. She felt tokenized, often the only black woman in a room of white interns and used to show donors and parents that the organization is “diverse.” She wondered: *Why was I hired? Was it because you saw something in me, or was it because you saw something in my blackness?* I have felt this way too as a queer woman. If you are any kind of minority, then your job is also helping the company find others like you to hire or answering questions about being that minority.

When I worked at BuzzFeed, for instance, my job was being a video creator, but it was also spearheading queer events, answering questions straight people had about queer content, and making content related only to my queerness. Your job is your job, and then you have a second job: professional minority. Unpaid internships can have this insidious consequence, requiring additional labor from minorities, also without compensation.